

Interim Founding Engineer — Tempo

3-month full-time engagement · start ASAP · potential to extend

About Tempo

Tempo is the intelligence layer for private-equity portfolio reporting. Sponsors run their portfolio companies on Excel templates — monthly flash packs, KPI dashboards, board reporting — and today those templates are filled by hand, month after month, company after company. Tempo understands a sponsor's template once, deeply: every input, every formula, every convention. From then on, any portfolio company's data pack fills it automatically — from the web app or directly from a task pane inside Excel — with every number traceable to its source, every write verified deterministically, and every judgment call surfaced as a one-tap question whose answer is remembered forever.

The architecture has a firm spine: the LLM proposes meaning, deterministic code verifies and executes, the user resolves genuine ambiguity once, and the contract remembers. The core engine works today — real templates onboard, real data packs fill them, and a ground-truth evaluation suite scores every change against owner-labelled workbooks. What it needs now is an engineer to help take it from a working system to a product in customers' hands.

The role

You will work side-by-side with the founder as the interim owner of the platform build: shaping the architecture, shipping daily, and carrying features end to end — Python engine, Next.js app, Excel add-in, and the infrastructure underneath all three. This is a hands-on, high-ownership role for someone who is comfortable being the only engineer in the room: you will make pragmatic calls, hold a high bar where it matters (correctness of financial numbers is the product), and move fast everywhere else. Development here is AI-accelerated — you should be fluent working with AI coding tools and directing them well, and equally capable of reading, verifying, and hardening what they produce.

What you will build (3-month arc)

Month 1 — production foundations.

- Take the platform from local dev to deployed staging + production: containerise the FastAPI parsing/population service and the Next.js app, CI/CD with the existing test and eval suites as gates, secrets management, backups, monitoring and alerting.
- Authentication, organisations and multi-tenancy on Supabase/Postgres (RLS), so sponsors and portfolio companies each see exactly their own templates, data and questions.
- Harden the Excel add-in for real users: hosted task pane, sign-in from the pane, and centralised deployment via the Microsoft 365 admin centre.

Month 2 — scale the engine's operations.

- Re-architect long-running work (template onboarding, populate runs) onto a proper queue/worker model with streamed progress, retries, resumability and per-run cost caps — replacing the current in-process execution.
- Wire the evaluation suite into CI as a regression gate: every engine change is scored against the ground-truth labelled workbooks before it merges; track fill accuracy, incorrect-write rate, LLM cost and latency budgets.

- Ship product surface with the founder: the review-question inbox, the template contract UX, onboarding visualisation, and the add-in fill experience.

Month 3 — pilot-ready.

- Support first sponsor pilots end to end: onboard their real templates, run their real data packs, close the loop on failures fast.
- Security posture for financial data: access controls, audit logging, data retention, and the groundwork for SOC 2.
- Reliability hardening, load and failure testing, and clean handover documentation for the permanent team.

Technical requirements (must-have)

- Senior full-stack engineer (typically 5+ years) fluent in BOTH modern Python and TypeScript.
- Python: FastAPI, Pydantic, async patterns, and production service design; comfortable in a large, test-covered codebase.
- TypeScript/React: Next.js App Router in production, component architecture, Tailwind.
- LLM product engineering: you have shipped features built on Anthropic/OpenAI APIs — prompt and context design, structured outputs, evaluation harnesses, cost control, and observability (LangSmith or equivalent). You know why 'plausible but wrong' is the failure mode that matters.
- PostgreSQL depth: schema design, migrations, row-level security; Supabase experience is a strong plus.
- Infrastructure ownership end to end: Docker, CI/CD (GitHub Actions or similar), and at least one of AWS/GCP/Azure/Fly/Render taken to production, including monitoring and incident response.
- Async/long-running workloads: queues, workers, streaming progress (SSE/WebSockets), idempotency and retries.
- Deep comfort with Excel as a data structure — formulas, references, formats, named ranges — and willingness to work at that level of detail daily.
- Evidence of 0→1 ownership: you have built and operated a real product with a very small team, and can show it.

Nice to have

- Office.js / Excel add-in development, or Aspose.Cells / openpyxl-class spreadsheet tooling.
- Private-equity or finance-adjacent domain: management accounts, flash reporting, KPI packs, consolidation.
- Agent orchestration frameworks (LangGraph or similar) and multi-model routing.
- Design sensibility — the product aims at a Harvey/Legora-grade bar.
- Security/compliance groundwork for financial data (SOC 2, ISO 27001).

How we work

- Directly with the founder, daily — short feedback loops, decisions made in hours not weeks.
- AI-accelerated development as the default; human judgment on architecture, correctness and taste as the differentiator.
- Correctness is sacred: the eval suite and the deterministic verification layer are the product's spine. Everything else is pragmatically fast.

- You will see the whole business, not a ticket queue: customer conversations, pilot feedback, roadmap trade-offs.

Engagement

- Interim contract, 3 months, full-time, starting as soon as possible.
- Potential to extend, or convert to a permanent founding-engineer role.